



EQUIFAX

Khadija, Jack & Emmy

Introduction & Table of Contents

Equifax is an Atlanta based consumer credit reporting company founded in 1899. It is the largest credit reporting company in the U.S. as part of the "big three" (Equifax, Transunion, Experian)

1.....	Title Page
2.....	Introduction & Table of Contents
3.....	News Framing Theory
4.....	News Framing Theory (continued)
5.....	Equifax Data Breach
6.....	News Coverage Analysis
7.....	Takeaway & Conclusions
8.....	References

News Framing Theory

- Framing refers to how media organizes, structures, and presents news stories to influence audience interpretation
- Reporters and editors routinely choose various approaches to presenting news stories (Hook & Pu, 2006, p. 169)
- Robert Entman describes framing as “selecting some aspects of a perceived reality and making them more salient in a communicating text” (Entman, 1993, p. 52)
 - *Framing lays the groundwork for understanding how media can subtly influence public opinion by highlighting specific details while ignoring others*
 - *Different frames can lead to **polarized** interpretations of the same event*

News Framing Theory (continued)

- Framing attributes to who society blames
 - *The news can significantly influence public perceptions of responsibility (Iyengar, 1991)*
 - *When news reports highlight government or institutional failings, audiences are more likely to hold those entities accountable for social problems (Iyengar, 1991)*
- Shanto Iyengar's work implies that news media framing not only informs the public but also shapes how responsibility is assigned during crises and political contexts

Equifax Data Breach

- In 2017, Equifax, one of the largest U.S. credit reporting agencies, suffered a massive data breach that exposed sensitive personal information of approximately 147 million consumers.
 - *Highly sensitive information, including names, Social Security numbers, birth dates, addresses, and, in some cases, driver's license numbers and credit card details were compromised.*
 - *Authorities, stakeholders, shareholders, and the public were notified six weeks later.*
 - *Some options were offered to those affected, but customers were not satisfied, as there were delays and issues with the website and credit monitoring offered.*
 - *Claims the six weeks to conduct their own investigation.*
 - *The FTC and various attorneys general investigated the company and breach after the public announcement, leading to the CEO stepping down from his role.*

*Growing Outrage Over Massive Equifax Data Breach | NBC
Nightly News*



News Coverage Analysis (NBC)

- News networks employed multiple framing strategies to shape public opinion.
- *NBC Nightly News* framed the breach as a vulnerability for consumers.
 - *Evidenced by headlines and interviews*
 - *“Congress, consumers demand answers”*
 - *Many believed this breach to be a significant threat to individual security and privacy*

News Coverage Analysis (NBC) [Key Points]

- NBC News linked Equifax's actions (or lack thereof) to systemic flaws in financial data protection.
- This narrative framed Equifax as an institution that valued profits over consumer safety.
 - *NBC's approach to personalize the breach illustrated the real-world harm that inflicted over 140 million consumers*

News Coverage Analysis (WGAL- NBC affiliate)

- This news coverage discusses the legitimacy of emails related to the breach settlement.
- The communication strategy is transparent, and trust building, while having a sense of urgency.
- WGAL is framing the breach settlement as a positive outcome & an expected and rightful resolution.

Key points:

- Focusing on the legitimacy of emails, news anchors have personal experience.
- The reason people thought the emails were scams was because there was a lack of exact payment information.
- “This is the email I got.”
- “This is legitimate folks, it is not a scam.”

Viewers receive Equifax data breach settlement email. Is it a scam? | WGAL-NBC



Takeaways & Conclusion

Some considerations Equifax and companies facing a similar crisis can take from this crisis are:

- Letting their audience know right away, allowing them autonomous control of the actions they can take
- Offering free and effective services to protect and manage their data
- Offering full and clear information about the crisis
- Managing skepticism, why is the company allowing people to wonder if the emails are scams?
- Have a goal of building trust- protect reputation this way.

References

- Christians, Clifford G., et al. *Media Ethics Cases and Moral Reasoning* Clifford G. Christians, Mark Fackler, Peggy J. Kreshel, William J. Brown, Yayu Feng, Holly K. Overton, and Kathy Brittain Richardson. Routledge, Taylor & Francis Group, 2025.
- Entman, R. M. (1993). Framing: Toward clarification of a fractured paradigm. *Journal of Communication*, 43(4), 51-58. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1460-2466.1993.tb01304.x>
- Equifax. “Who We Are.” *Who We Are*, www.equifax.com/about-equifax/who-we-are/. Accessed 9 Mar. 2025.
- Iyengar, S. (1991). *Is anyone responsible? How television frames political issues*. University of Chicago Press.
- <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=I5Y6kBfyno8> (NBC Nightly News)
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ljHw_qeybsQ (WGAL- NBC News.)